sense of his newfound penchant for all things scary, be it literature, blogs, podcasts or YouTube channels. "In small towns," he says, "I love to sit and chat with locals and get them to tell me stories about ghosts, apparitions and haunted places." Having directed three horcoms, his next in the genre, for Maddock Films, features vampires.

Sarpotdar cites *Bhool Bhulaiyaa* (2007) for setting the benchmark for horcom in Hindi cinema even if it was a remake of the beloved 1993 Malayalam film *Manichitrathazhu* starring Mohanlal, Suresh Gopi and Shobana. Says Sarpotdar, "With big spectacles, you get taken in by the visuals. With a horcom, you are in it for the experience of emotions. They tap into your imagination, play with the core emotions of fantasy, adventure and thrill."

EXPANDING THE UNIVERSE

Time was when amateurishly-done scenes of humans transforming into monsters would evoke laughter more than a scream. But with world-renowned VFX studios such as DNEG, Moving Picture Company and Digital Domain setting up shop in India, filmmakers now have the technical wherewithal to realise their scary visions. Namit Malhotra, CEO of the multiple Oscar-winning studio DNEG, is proud of the "terrifying yet comical antagonist" created in *Munjya*. "The challenge in the horror comedy genre is finding the right balance," he says, "the reason being that the creation of the characters in these projects should not only make them visually compelling but also enhance the horror and comedy elements affecting the audience's reception."

For Jyoti Deshpande, President, Media & Content Business, RIL, who has co-produced all Maddock horcoms barring *Munjya*, what makes *Stree 2*'s success impressive is that "money goes into production and is not lopsided to any one individual. The characters and storytelling and world-building have outlived everything else". So, none of Maddock's horcoms so far have been shot abroad; most are set in small towns and stay true to the genre in isolated settings. Never mind featuring stars, they have made stars out of Rajkummar Rao, Abhishek Banerjee, Pankaj Tripathi, Aparshakti Khurana, and put *Munjya* actors Abhay Varma and Sharvari on the map. What the 2024 horcoms have proven is that it's not only big-budget, star-heavy action dramas that work in cinemas. Spend money on creating compelling creatures—Munjya, Sarkata, Stree—and their back stories and audiences are game for some laughs and shrieks.

THE BUSINESS OF HORCOMS

As the Stree franchise takes off, Jio Studios is now looking to build the IP (intellectual property) and monetise it. Just like Disney has catered to its devoted fan base with its slate of Pixar and Marvel titles and Warner Bros with the DC Extended Universe, Deshpande too senses an opportunity. "In India, we have never been able to sell merchandise and gaming purely because our characters have never outlived stars," she says. "IP cannot just be making a large number in one outing, it is one that gives it an annuity income over a long period." She suggests a horcom musical a la *Wicked*, which could be staged at the NMACC in Mumbai, as an example of the genre's potential.

With great success, of course, comes great imitation. As the epicentre of the horcom universe, Maddock Films these days is inundated with scripts and concepts in the genre. But as Bhatt will know, it's not the easiest to crack, and overexploiting it may backfire. After all, for every *Stree* and *Munjya*, there's a *Bhoot Police* and *Phone Bhoot*, both of which bombed. Maddock's own *Bhediya* and *Roohi* were unable to repeat *Stree*'s success. "The question is, how long can this genre keep on pulling audiences into theatre? There will be a burnout with an excess of horror comedies," says Sarpotdar. It's why Kaushik, Vijan and Bhatt are taking their time delivering the next instalments of *Bhediya*, *Stree* and *Munjya*. "We have to take care of this universe," says Kaushik. "If we make correct films, money will come." *Stree 2* is certainly laughing all the way to the bank. ■



> **"THE BEAUTY OF THIS GENRE IS THAT UNLIKE DRAMA, A HORROR COMEDY IS A MEDIUM FOR SPONTANEOUS REACTION FROM AUDIENCES. IT IS A COMMUNITY EXPERIENCE"**
>
> **— NIREN BHATT**
> ***Screenwriter and lyricist***

Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR